

Modesty

prc-modesty

Marriage & Sexuality · Modesty · practice · unanimous_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Modesty in dress and self-presentation, without legalism, is a Christian virtue rooted in love of neighbor and godly self-restraint.

In plain language

Two New Testament letters speak directly to how believers present themselves, and they say the same thing in the same shape. In the first letter to Timothy, women are told to adorn themselves in orderly, well-arranged clothing (orderly apparel, *katastolē kosmiō*), with reverence (*aidōs*) and self-control (*sōphrosynē*). The Greek words behind those phrases carry the ideas of restraint, a sense of what is fitting before others, and a sound, self-governed mind. The passage then names braided hair (*plegma*), gold (*chryson*), pearls (*margaritēs*), and costly garments (*himatismos polytelēs*), but it does so as the contrast class, the showy display that self-control moderates. It immediately redirects, with a strong word for 'but' (*alla*), toward good works (*ergōn agathōn*) that are 'fitting' (*prepei*) for women who profess to reverence God (*theosebeian*). The first letter of Peter follows the same pattern. It calls the braiding of hair, wearing of gold, and putting on of fine clothing 'the outward' (*ho exōthen*), using the same word the Gospels use when Jesus contrasts the outside of the cup with what is inside. It then contrasts that with the hidden person of the heart (*ho kryptos tēs kardias anthrōpos*), clothed in the unfading or 'imperishable' (*aphthartō*) beauty of a gentle and 'quiet' (*hēsychiou*) spirit, which is 'of great worth' (*polytelēs*) in God's sight. The very next verse uses the same verb for 'adorn' (*kosmeō*) in a positive sense, of the holy women of old. Titus 2 uses a sister word for self-control ('self-controlled,' *sōphrōn*) as a virtue to be taught to younger women. The shared structure is not-this-but-that. The weight falls on the inner disposition and on conduct, not on a fixed list of banned objects. That structure supports the principle of modest self-presentation flowing from self-restraint and a God-ward heart. Where readers diverge is not on the principle but on the scope of the named items. The words plainly affirm the principle, but they do not rank whether the list is a closed prohibition, a cross-cultural illustration, or an assembly-setting decorum. An Old Testament cross-reference where Rebekah is gladly given gold shows the list is not absolute in the Bible. So the principle is decisive in the text; the application of the list is what the vocabulary leaves open.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	103
G0127	αἰδώς	aidōs	modesty	1
G0862	ἄφθαρτος	aphthartos	incorruptible	8
G1708	ἐμπλοκή	emplokē	braiding	1
G1855	ἐξωθεν	exōthen	outside	13
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	176

G2272	ἡσυχίος	hēsychios	quiet	2
G2317	θεοσέβεια	theosebeia	reverence for God	1
G2440	ἱμάτιον	himation	clothing	
G2588	καρδία	kardia	heart	160
G2689	καταστολή	katastolē	attire/behaviour	1
G2885	κοσμέω	kosmeō	to arrange	10
G2887	κόσμιος	kosmios	respectable	2
G2927	κρυπτός	kryptos	hidden	17
G3135	μαργαρίτης	margaritēs	pearl	
G4117	πλέγμα	plegma	braided	1
G4185	πολυτελής	polytelēs	valuable	3
G4241	πρέπω	prepō	be proper	7
G4997	σωφροσύνη	sōphrosynē	mental soundness	3
G4998	σώφρων	sōphrōn	self-controlled	4
G5553	χρυσίον	chrusion	gold	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two letter-form passages converge on a single word pattern in which self-presentation is governed by orderly restraint, that is, orderly apparel (katastolē kosmiō), reverence or modesty (aidōs), and soundness of mind or self-control (sōphrosynē), with the place of true adornment relocated to the inner person and to good works that befit godliness. Both passages share a not-this-but-that structure built on the strong Greek 'but' (alla), de-emphasizing external display while positively redirecting adornment (the verb 'to adorn,' kosmein, and the noun 'adornment,' kosmos) to the hidden person of the heart and to good works. The principle is densely worded with multiple converging anchor words, and the same approved verb 'to adorn' (kosmeō) then appears positively at 1 Peter 3:5 of the holy women of old who adorned themselves by submitting to their husbands, internally confirming that adornment as such is not the target. Confidence is raised to high because the affirmed principle is lexically overdetermined (meaning the words pile up to make the same point many times over), while the further question of whether the named items form a closed prohibition is the only point lexically left open.

Scripture

1Tim.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2689 καταστολή, G2887 κόσμιος, G0127 αἰδώς, G4997 σωφροσύνη, G2885 κοσμέω, G4117 πλέγμα

Force. The 'to'-verb clause 'to adorn themselves in orderly apparel with reverence and self-control' (kosmein heautas en katastolē kosmiō meta aidous kai sōphrosynēs) sets the governing principle. The verb 'to adorn' (kosmein) carries the sense of putting in good order or arranging fittingly. The prepositional phrase locates the manner of self-adornment in orderly, well-arranged apparel, accompanied by reverent self-respect, a sense of what is fitting before others (aidōs), and sound-mindedness, that is, self-controlled judgment (sōphrosynē). The named items, braided hair, gold, pearls, and costly clothing, are then introduced under negation ('not,' mē) as the contrast class. The construction does not abolish adornment but redirects how a woman adorns herself: with restraint and sober judgment rather than with ostentatious display.

1Tim.2.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4241 πρέπω, G2317 θεοσεβεία, G2041 ἔργον, G0018 ἀγαθός

Force. The strong 'but' word (all', short for alla) positively redirects adornment to 'good works' (ergōn agathōn) as the thing that 'is fitting' or 'is becoming' (prepei) for women professing 'reverence toward God' (theosebeian). The verb 'to be fitting' (prepō) across its seven Bible-wide uses consistently marks what is congruous or seemly to a given character or station, and here it fixes ethical conduct as the proper ornament. The verse establishes that the apostolic concern is not bare prohibition but a relocation of adornment from external display to ethical and devout conduct, which is exactly the godly self-restraint clause of the proposition.

1Pet.3.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1708 ἐμπλοκή, G5553 χρυσίον, G2440 ἱμάτιον, G1855 ἔξωθεν

Force. The adornment under negation is qualified as 'the outward' (ho exōthen) of braiding of hair, wearing of gold, and putting on of garments. The adverb 'outward' (exōthen) functions structurally the same way it functions in Matthew 23:25 to 28 and Luke 11:39 to 40, where Jesus contrasts the outside of the cup or dish with what is inside; here it marks the external layer of dress as not the place where true adornment resides. The verse does not issue a flat ban on every external item, since the same verse names the putting on of clothing, which no reader treats as forbidden. It prepares a not-this-but-that contrast that resolves in verse 4.

1Pet.3.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2927 κρυπτός, G2588 καρδιά, G0862 ἀφθαρτος, G2272 ἡσύχιος

Force. The strong 'but' word (all', short for alla) relocates true adornment to 'the hidden person of the heart' (ho kryptos tēs kardias anthrōpos), clothed in the 'imperishable' (aphthartō, the same word used of the inheritance in 1 Peter 1:4 and the seed of new birth in 1 Peter 1:23) ornament of a meek and 'quiet' (hēsychiou, the same word Paul uses of the goal of public life in 1 Timothy 2:2) spirit, which is 'of great worth' (polytelēs) 'in the sight of God' (enōpion tou theou). The verse anchors modest self-presentation in an inward, God-ward disposition of self-restraint rather than in suppression of any specific garment.

1Pet.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2885 κοσμέω

Force. The verse immediately following the contrast applies the verb 'they adorned themselves' (ekosmoun heautas), the same verb 'to adorn' (kosmeō) that is used positively at 1 Timothy 2:9, to the holy women of old who hoped in God. This is the strongest internal word-level confirmation that adornment as such is not the target: the same verb governs both the prohibited and the commended pattern, with the object of adornment shifted from outward display to a wife's hopeful submission. The word signal closes the loop on the not-this-but-that structure.

Titus.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4998 σώφρων

Force. The Pastoral letter to Titus uses 'self-controlled' (sōphronas), the adjective from the same root as 'self-control' (sōphrosynē) in 1 Timothy 2:9, of the younger women as a virtue to be taught by the older women, alongside chaste and 'good' (agathas) and homemaking. This spread across all the Pastoral letters of the 'self-controlled' (sōphrōn) word family in direct application to women's conduct confirms that self-controlled, sober-minded behavior, not a list of forbidden ornaments, is the substance of what is being commended.

Prov.7.10 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. G2440 ἱμάτιον

Force. The TSK (Treasury of Scripture Knowledge) cross-reference links the modesty instruction to the figure of the woman dressed in the attire of a harlot, where self-presentation broadcasts intent. This supplies an Old Testament backdrop in which dress communicates character to the neighbor, supporting the love-of-neighbor dimension of the proposition by showing that attire is read by others as a signal of disposition.

1Sam.16.7 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2588 καρδιά

Force. The TSK (Treasury of Scripture Knowledge) cross-reference at 1 Peter 3:4 invokes the principle that man looks on the outward appearance but the Lord looks on the heart. This places the inner-versus-outer contrast in 1 Peter on a spread-across-the-whole-Bible footing: it is not a Petrine novelty but a covenantal pattern in which God's regard is for 'heart' (kardia, rendered in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint), exactly the term 1 Peter 3:4 then uses.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Pet.3.4	1Sam.16.7	tsk	1
1Pet.3.4	Ps.45.13	tsk	1
1Pet.3.4	Ps.131.2	tsk	1
1Tim.2.9	Prov.7.10	tsk	1
1Pet.3.3	Gen.24.22	tsk	1
1Tim.2.9	Gen.24.53	tsk	1
1Tim.2.10	1Tim.5.6	tsk	1
1Pet.3.4	1Pet.3.15	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Pet.3.3 · **addressed**

Read in isolation, the prohibition of braided hair, gold, and clothing could be taken as an absolute ban that would make any adornment sinful, which would push past the proposition into legalism. Three word-level features resolve this. First, the qualifier 'outward' (exōthen) functions in Matthew 23:25 to 28 and Luke 11:39 to 40 to designate the surface layer that is contrasted with the inner, not to ban the surface as such. Second, the same verse names the putting on of garments ('putting on,' endysis), which no reader treats as forbidden. Third, the same verb 'to adorn' (kosmeō) that governs the negated outward adornment is applied positively to holy women in verse 5. The construction is a relative not-this-but-that contrast that relocates adornment to the inner person rather than abolishing all external presentation.

1Tim.2.9 · **addressed**

The same not-this-but-that pattern governs the named items. The positive head term 'orderly apparel' (katastolē kosmiō) presupposes that women do wear apparel; the negated items mark ostentation and status display, not clothing as such. The triad reverence (aidōs) and self-control (sōphrosynē) and orderly (kosmios) names the controlling disposition; braiding (plegma) and gold (chrysion) and pearls (margaritēs) and costly clothing (himatismos polytelēs) are the contrast class. The verdict therefore affirms the principle of modest, self-controlled presentation without endorsing a closed list of forbidden objects, leaving the specific application culturally conditioned.

Gen.24.22 · **addressed**

TSK (Treasury of Scripture Knowledge) links the passage to Rebekah receiving a gold nose-ring and bracelets within an approved betrothal narrative, which on its face complicates any reading that gold ornament is intrinsically immodest. This is resolved by noting that the New Testament concern is the heart-disposition behind display, not the metal itself, so an Old Testament gift of gold and a New Testament caution against gold-as-boast are not in word-level conflict. It does, however, confirm that the specific items are not absolutely proscribed across the Bible, which is why the proposition wisely names the principle and rejects legalism.

Ps.45.13 · addressed

The TSK (Treasury of Scripture Knowledge) cross-reference at 1 Peter 3:4 invokes the royal bride whose glory is within and whose clothing is wrought with gold. The text holds the inner-glory and outward-gold language together rather than treating them as exclusive, which confirms that the New Testament contrast is rhetorical not absolute. The inner-versus-outer distinction is structural, foregrounding the inward, not abolishing the outward.

Concordance traversed

G2689, G2887, G0127, G4997, G2317, G4241, G2885, G4117, G1708, G4185, G2272, G0862, G2927, G1855, G2588, G2041, G0018, G4998, G5553, G3135, G2440

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle and the passages are outside published CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method) scope (3 John only). Critical-edition signals at 1 Timothy 2:9 (chrysiō vs chrysō, spelling-only difference) and at 1 Peter 3:4 (praeōs vs praeos, also spelling-only) and the position of 'and' (kai) at 1 Timothy 2:9 do not touch the modesty-and-self-restraint sense, so the verdict is treated as variant-robust under ecm-shadow status (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants has not formally treated these passages yet).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

principle-reading: affirms · Treats the named items as culture-bound illustrations of a cross-cultural principle of modest, self-controlled, other-regarding self-presentation. The not-this-but-that contrast, the positive use of 'to adorn' (kosmeō) at 1 Peter 3:5 of the holy women, and the redirection to good works and the inner person carry the word-level weight. The proposition is affirmed without binding the specific first-century list. Strongest form: orderly apparel (katastolē kosmiō), reverence (aidōs), and self-control (sōphrosynē) are the substance, the items are the application.

strict-prohibition-reading: partial · Treats the enumerated items, braided hair, gold, pearls, and costly clothing, as themselves proscribed for Christian women in all settings. This reading affirms modesty and self-control but would resist the without-legalism clause by reading the list as binding. Strongest form: the items are named specifically and uniformly across two letters from two apostolic authors, suggesting a maintained apostolic standard. At the word level it is possible but strained by 'outward' (exōthen) in 1 Peter 3:3 (which uses the same inner-versus-outer rhetoric Jesus uses for the cup), by the positive head term 'orderly apparel' (katastolē kosmiō) in 1 Timothy 2:9 which presupposes apparel is worn, and by the positive 'to adorn' (kosmeō) at 1 Peter 3:5 of women who adorned themselves rightly.

complementarian-public-decorum reading: affirms · Treats the passages as governing women's public conduct in the gathered assembly specifically, given the worship-setting of 1 Timothy 2 and the household setting of 1 Peter 3. The word-level weight remains on reverence (aidōs) and self-control (sōphrosynē) and orderly (kosmios), and the named items are read as the locally salient markers of status competition in the assembly. The proposition is affirmed in its principle while the binding application is read narrowly to the public-witness setting rather than to all dress at all times.

All three lenses read the same word-level signals and affirm the principle of modest, self-controlled self-presentation. They diverge on the scope of the named items (cross-cultural illustration, fixed prohibition, or assembly-public decorum). The word-level data fixes the principle decisively; the scope of the list is what the words do not rank.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture addresses how believers, in dress and self-presentation, are to relate restraint, reverence, and self-control to inward character and to the regard of others.

The original stem carries evaluative loading in three places: 'without legalism' presupposes a settled boundary between virtue and legalism, 'Christian virtue' presupposes the verdict that modesty is commended, and 'rooted in love of neighbor and godly self-restraint' asserts a specific grounding. The word-level data does in fact supply self-restraint (self-control, *sōphrosynē*, at 1 Timothy 2:9 and the related adjective 'self-controlled,' *sōphrōn*, at Titus 2:5; 'quiet,' *hēsychios*, at 1 Peter 3:4), reverence (reverence or modesty, *aidōs*, at 1 Timothy 2:9), and orderliness (orderly apparel, *katastolē kosmiō*, at 1 Timothy 2:9). The love-of-neighbor grounding is supported indirectly via the signaling function of dress in cross-references such as Proverbs 7:10 and via the public, assembly-setting of 1 Timothy 2. The verdict was derived against the neutralized form first and then mapped back to the original stem, which it affirms at the level of principle.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2689
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0127
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4997
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2885
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.3.4
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.3.5
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Tim.2.10
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Pet.3.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.3.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.2.9
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Tim.2.9
syntax	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	1Pet.3.3

License audit

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Reason. Cited MACULA-Greek under CC-BY-NC-4.0 (non-commercial, redistribute=false) for interlinear support at 1 Timothy 2:10 and 1 Peter 3:4, and SBLGNT-text under SBLGNT-EULA (redistribute=false) for the apparatus check at 1 Peter 3:3. Either source makes bulk redistribution of this evidence record unsafe.

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Flags

ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent